

girl woke at 6:45 a.m. My contractions were every 10 minutes and getting stronger, so my husband stayed home.

By 8:00 a.m., my contractions were every 5 minutes, stronger, and lasting 50–60 seconds. My husband called the midwife. She said she was on her way and advised me to stay active. I started to use the [TENS](#) machine on a low setting, which helped me focus. I found standing and rocking my pelvis back and forth and from side to side helpful and I used a birthing ball. My husband was supportive, massaging my shoulders and under my abdomen where it hurt most; I found the heat from his hands soothing. My daughter held my hand.

At 8:40 a.m., the midwife arrived. She checked my blood pressure, pulse, and temperature, felt my belly, listened to the baby's heart, and took a urine sample, which relieved some pressure in my pubic area. She confirmed that I was in established labor since my cervix was 5 cm dilated. My cervix was thinning, the head was pressing down, and my membranes were intact. I stayed active, using TENS, and leaning forward. My partner put on relaxing music.

At 9:50 a.m., my contractions were every two minutes, very strong, and lasting 60 seconds. I tried walking and marching on the spot. My mom arrived and took my daughter to the park. I felt hot and so I had a cool drink and my midwife dabbed my face with a cool, wet cloth. I found kneeling on all fours, rocking and arching my back, helpful.

By 10:30 a.m., my contractions were very painful. My midwife listened to the heartbeat intermittently.

By 11:00 a.m., I felt an urge to push. My water broke and my contractions were very strong and each minute. I felt panicky, but my midwife encouraged me, saying she thought the baby would be born soon; my husband helped me focus by breathing slowly. My midwife confirmed that I was fully dilated and ready to push. I somehow found the energy to bear down and felt the head emerge. I took a breath, concentrated, and pushed my baby out.

My baby boy was born at 11:14 a.m., 8 lb 2 oz, and my husband cut the cord once it had stopped pulsating. I delivered my placenta without drugs (see [Delivering the placenta naturally](#)). My midwife advised me to put my baby to my breast to stimulate the hormone oxytocin, which causes contractions and helps the placenta to come away. My placenta was delivered at 11:40 a.m.

The midwife's comments: Jenna and her husband prepared well and worked as a team. Jenna was active for most of labor and stayed focused. Her feelings of panic in the transition period were normal, but her husband and I gave her extra support. By working with her instincts, she found inner strength and had a normal birth. Her labor was nine hours, about average for a second-time mom.